FIGHTING MERITS

They say you sweat in training to avoid bleeding in combat, but sometimes the bleeding comes first.. Survivors debrief experiences, codify them, and pass them on. Students and rivals tweak techniques to account for new experiences, methods, rituals, and aesthetics.

Deconstructing Fighting Styles

Chronicles of Darkness models Fighting Styles through two mechanisms. First, a linear Merit ladder that represents steps on the way to mastering the style. Second, individual Merits list Style Merits as prerequisites. They're optional abilities that further distinguish characters from one another.

In this chapter, we're breaking that structure. Characters can now learn styles in a much less structured fashion, though you don't have to change existing characters. The **Chronicles of Darkness** rules stay the same. Yet we want to free Fighting Styles from formal martial arts and other rigidly defined backgrounds. So first, let's present new systems for learning, mastering, and defining your own styles.

Style and Background

Some styles have informal names. Others take the names of real martial arts. In both cases, take style names as suggestions to help incorporate a style into a character's history. For example, the Systema name suggests that characters with this style might be students of that martial art, but a player could just as easily decide that the character's a dedicated student of modern dance with special body skills. The style's prerequisites, systems, and Style Tags (see below) take priority over their names and histories, but we've still included that information to make it easy to pick Merits to fit character backgrounds.

On the other hand, many real-world training regimens are too complex to be encompassed by a single style. Some Chinese and Japanese martial arts teach dozens of weapons and special skills. Police and military training demand more than the ability to shoot and internalize a few combative tricks. Nevertheless, you can claim a character's been comprehensively trained, because a Fighting Style represents specialized focus on a form of combat, not basic exposure. Most training is already a function of your character's Skills. Your elite Russian operative might train in Close Quarters Combat, Firefight, Light Weapons, and Systema but you don't need all those Merits to represent that. Pick Merits for one or two special talents, not every hour of training.

Other Styles could be easily modified to suit specific chronicle needs. For example, a **Vampire: The Requiem** character who can speak with and train bobcats could very well use the K-9 Style to represent that relationship, even though a bobcat is not the required dog.

Stacking Fighting Merits

Can you use more than one Fighting Style maneuver or other Merit in a single attack? Sometimes. The following rules apply.

1. If nobody can explain how the maneuvers would stack in the story, it doesn't work. The player needs to describe an action that brings them together. Your two-pistol backflip neck breaker's probably going to sound dumb — unless you can somehow make it sound *amazing*.
2. The required equipment or other circumstances for all maneuvers used must be present.
3. You can't stack Fighting Merits that penalize one of your character's traits more than once, or impose the same disadvantage more than once. For example, you cannot stack two Merits that lower Defense, even if they cumulatively would not reduce Defense below zero.
4. You can't stack maneuvers that use different dice pools, unless changing the dice pool is a benefit the Merit specifically confers. For example, you can

Why Can't I Do It Without the Merit?

Some of the Merits in this section represent things most combatants may be capable of, such as specific targeted attacks and general martial arts maneuvers. There's nothing to say a character can't use a trunk squeeze while wrestling without the Trunk Squeeze Merit. However, he doesn't have the specialized training necessary to benefit from the specific mechanics listed in the Merit.

use Fighting Finesse with maneuvers that require Strength + Weaponry, and they'll use Dexterity + Weaponry instead, but you can't combine a Merit that uses Weaponry with one that uses Brawl.

5. When stacked maneuvers provide the same benefit, the higher of the two apply. All disadvantages apply (though remember that you can't stack maneuvers that impose the same disadvantage twice). Note that when two maneuvers provide the same result by different means, they *do* stack, so the Rote benefit (re-roll failed dice) does stack with bonus dice.

Style Tags

In these rules, most Fighting Merits have *Style Tags*. These define a Merit's basic category, how it functions, and most importantly, its relationship with similar Merits. Most Merits utilize the following Style Tags. Avoid inventing new ones, as it disconnects them from existing Merits and keeps players from developing their own Fighting Styles. In addition, the Style Tag lists currently published styles that fall under these tags.

Archery: Using a hand-drawn bow, as opposed to a crossbow (which normally uses Pistol or Rifle). **Styles: Bowmanship and Combat Archery**

Attitude (and Keywords): These styles don't rely on movement, but channel an emotional state or motivation into the focus to fight. Note that this actually stands for a number of tags with specific keywords representing emotional states. To help create styles, create new keywords sparingly. The default keywords are: Calm, Cautious, Determined, Enraged, Retributive. **Styles:** Berserker (Enraged), Relentless Assault (Determined)

Creature (Keyword): Styles that use the natural capabilities of creatures that don't have a strictly human form, including animals and certain monstrous beings. Keywords define individual Style Tags. Default Keywords are: Avian, Bite, Claw, and Constrictor. **Styles:** K-9 (Bite), Falconry (Claw)

Flexible: Chain weapons, rope weapons, flails, nunchaku, and other weapons that strike with a combination of weight and transfer through flexible cords or weights. **Styles:** Chain Weapons

Grappling: Practitioners grab opponents to strangle them, pin them, hyperextend their limbs, and throw them. **Styles:** Grappling

Heavy Melee: Using a blade or club that is best wielded with two hands, but isn't operated with evenly spaced hands like a Pole Weapon — two-handed swords and big clubs qualify. Note that some weapons might be used as both Heavy Melee and Pole Weapons. **Styles:** Armed Defense, Heavy Weapons, Mounted Combat

Light Melee: Using a blade or club that can easily be wielded in one hand. **Styles:** Armed Defense, Light Weapons, Mounted Combat

Movement (and Keywords): Ways of moving to optimize fighting or athletic ability. This Style Tag is actually several, each with its own keyword. Avoid creating new keywords so that it's possible to match Merits into a style based on keyword-specific Style Tags. Default Keywords: Agile, Strong, Tough. **Styles:** Parkour (Agile), Strength Performance (Strong), Systema (Agile)

Pistol: Using a pistol or pistol-gripped ranged weapon that does not require a stock, such as a dart gun or modern miniature crossbow. **Styles:** Firefight, Marksmanship, Powered Projectile

Pole Weapons: These styles teach the use of staves, spears, polearms, and other long-hafted weapons. Some weapons might be used as both Heavy Melee and Pole Weapons. **Styles:** Staff Fighting

Rifle: Operating a hunting or assault rifle, or other long-ranged weapon that typically employs a shoulder stock. **Styles:** Firefight, Marksmanship

Striking: The focus is on striking with fists, feet, elbows, knees, and other human "natural weapons." Inhuman natural weapons are the province of Creature styles. Striking may function with weapons that utilize the Brawl Skill. **Styles:** Boxing, Martial Arts, Unarmed Defense

Tactical (Keyword): These styles represent trade skills and tricks from certain professions, such as police or members of the military. Each profession has its own Keyword, and when attached to the tag, creates a specific Style Tag. Default Keywords: Military, Police, Street. Create new Keywords only if they can be attached to enough Merits to create a significant Fighting Style. **Styles:** Close Quarters Combat (Military), Improvised Weapons (Street), Street Fighting (Street), Police Tactics (Police)

Using Style Tags

On one hand, you can choose to purchase the next level of a Fighting Style as usual, for the cost of a single Merit dot. The standard **Chronicles of Darkness** rules apply. If a Fighting Style possesses alternate maneuvers, you may add the "standard" or alternate maneuver to your character this way.

Yet your character might abandon orthodox advancement. If she chooses this route, you may purchase any maneuver for the price of a one-dot Fighting Merit and add it to her abilities. The catch? The character needs to first possess as many Merit dots in the same Style Tag as the rank (in Fighting Style progression) of the unorthodox or extra maneuver she wishes to learn. This investment can take the form of maneuvers (for one dot each) or Merits with a matching Style Tag (which may have variable Merit dot costs). This restriction also applies to characters who wish to learn more than one alternate maneuver in a single style.

Style Tags can't override prerequisite Attribute and Skill ratings, prerequisite maneuvers (such as exist in many Grappling maneuvers), and other special requirements, noted with each style.

Example: *Musa was a Dambe boxer in Nigeria, but thought he'd left the hobby behind when he went to MIT. But recent events plunged him into weird, violent scenarios, so it's time for him to continue his training. He studies at a local Muay Thai gym. Musa knows the first two dots of Boxing (Striking) and the two-dot version of Iron Chin, which also uses the Striking tag. That gives him four dots of Merits that fall under Striking. The gym teaches the Martial Arts style, which also uses the Striking tag, in the following progression: Leg Kick •, Cutting Elbow ••, Whirlwind Strike •••, The Hand as Weapon ••••, and High Momentum Strike •••••. Musa's four dots of Striking Merits allow him to learn anything up to The Hand as Weapon without methodically advancing up the style. His player decides to pay the cost of The Hand as Weapon (as a one-dot Merit) and Musa hits the heavy bag. After dedicated training, Musa now knows the following maneuvers: Head Protection (Boxing •), Defensive Jab (Boxing ••), and The Hand as Weapon (Martial Arts ••••). Combined with the Iron Chin that represented enough raw experience to skip a certain amount of formal training, Musa has evolved into a deadly puncher. Of course, his coaches lambast his terrible kicking technique, and nag him to work on it and become a well-rounded fighter.*

Style Merits

The following are all new Style Merits which use the tagging system listed above.

Avoidance (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Manipulation •••, Athletics ••, Stealth ••
Style Tags: Movement (Agile)

Effect: Your character's only goal in a fight is not to get hurt. She tries to create situations where opponents hurt themselves or target her big mean friends instead. There is no formal training for this Style; it's a mixture of ingenuity and a person's innate desire to avoid pain.

Insignificance (•): When a fight starts you ease out of sight and try to become a part of the scenery. Make a roll of Manipulation + Stealth – the highest Composure in the room. If successful, your character comes across as very non-threatening. Unless an opponent perceives no other threats around him whatsoever she cannot be the direct target of his attacks. This effect ends if she attacks or takes any threatening actions during the scene.

Coattails (••): Your character's reaction to being attacked is to dive behind her bigger friend and let him take care of it. When taking a Dodge action she can designate an ally in close range whose hasn't attacked yet that turn. Go Prone. If hit by an opponent's attack, her ally can choose to take the damage.

Whack-a-Mole (•••): Your character makes herself into a tempting target and unsuspecting opponents end up doing more damage to themselves than her. Once per turn you may make a contested roll of Manipulation + Persuasion + Avoidance against an opponent's unarmed or melee attack roll. If the character gets the most successes the attack does no damage, and instead inflicts the Arm Wrack Tilt on the opponent.

Play Dead (••••): When your character wants to bow out of a combat she makes even the most superficial wounds look fatal. After any attack your character sustained lethal damage from, roll Manipulation + Subterfuge. Opponents require a contested Wits + Composure roll to notice that she's still alive.

Berserker (Style; • to •••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Iron Stamina •••
Style Tags: Attitude (Enraged)

Effect: Your character enters a controlled madness in combat. Whether a believer in the throes of ecstatic fervor

The Best Style

Martial arts, combat sports, and training for crisis-prone professions each have their own methods, philosophies, and objectives. As cultural products these things mutate, mash together, and shift context, but there's always the feeling that the stakes are high enough that it's not enough to just learn to fight, but learn the very best way.

So martial artists annoy each other with differences of opinion all the damn time.

Exponents of combat sports like Muay Thai and MMA exchange plenty of unkind words with advocates of traditional styles like karate. Fans of "reality-based self-defense" methods based on police and military tactics think everybody else is stuck in rules and traditions. People who like guns just say they'll shoot all these assholes. Style and school rivalries break out all the time. It's mostly trash talk, but sometimes people come to blows at formal tournaments or closed-door "training sessions." Stories readily erupt from these sorts of conflicts.

This book doesn't take any particular position because it's more fun if we cast a wide net, and don't tell you that such and such a method is garbage. On the other hand, in the **Chronicles of Darkness** a strip mall karate school where most of the students are under 12 is never going to make you a "warrior," and regardless of what you believe, we assume that without supernatural powers, knocking someone out requires you to pound them, not lightly tap pressure point GB-12 with Crane Hand. (Fun fact: GB-12 is behind the ear and yes, getting punched behind the ear is bad.) In the **Chronicles of Darkness**, fighting is a sweat-drenched trade that leaves bruises, breaks, and lacerations.

or a warrior emulating the Norse berserks, this Style is not about technique but about achieving the right state of mind.

The Red Mist (•): Your character focuses inward, seeking out her source of rage within. By spending a point of Willpower she inflicts the Insane Tilt on herself for the remainder of the scene.

War Cry (••): Your character chills an opponent's blood with her mad howl. Instead of attacking, roll a contested Strength + Intimidation versus opponent's Resolve + Composure. If your character gets the most successes, her opponent suffers a penalty equal to your successes to any action other than Dodging for the next turn.

Manic Brutality (•••): Your character lashes out with a single-minded determination to destroy. Her all-out unarmed attacks have a +1 bonus to hit specified targets. If she's using a weapon then she may substitute its Durability for its weapon bonus.

Drawback: If she's using a weapon, then all damage taken by her opponent is also applied directly to the weapon's Structure.

Bowmanship (Style: • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Firearms ••, Trained Observer •

Style Tags: Archery

Effect: Your character is a patient hunter with a bow. She fires precision shots across long distances to take out targets that had no idea she was even there. This Style focuses on a character's ability to aim by judging distance and trajectory. It uses a dice pool of Dexterity + Firearms for its attacks.

Arcing Fire (•): Your character knows how to tilt her aim to make a shot hit true even from afar. Double range increments, or increase her range band by one degree.

Bullseye (••): Your character places her shots to hit deep into an opponent's weak spots. When attacking a specified target you may lower your bow's damage rating to any amount (0 or greater) to add +1 and the 8-again quality to the attack roll.

Out of Nowhere (•••): Your character fires her arrows and then ducks out of sight, leaving her enemies bleeding and confused. Roll Dexterity + Stealth as a reflexive action after attacking a target that is unaware of her presence. Her target must roll Wits + Composure – her successes, where failure applies the Shaken Conditionand the attacker is hidden.

Death from Above (••••): Loose vertical shots to reach opponents behind cover. Reduce their Concealment by 1 per 10 yards (9 meters) added to the shot's range. Or ignore entirely by reducing range band by one degree.

Boxing (Style: • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Strength ••, Dexterity ••, Stamina ••, Brawl ••, Athletics ••

Style Tags: Striking

Effect: Trading blows with the hands dates back to Classical times, and probably earlier — some biologists believe our hands have been optimized to deliver blows. There are hundreds of folk styles of boxing, from West Africa's *Dambe* to the Filipino method known as *Suntukan* or *Panantukan*.

This style concentrates on the modern combat sport, which combines European methods with innovations developed by trainers or borrowed from other cultures. Your character is trained in modern boxing, or a similar traditional style.

Head Protection (•): The head is the primary target for most boxers, so your character has learned to protect it by bobbing, weaving, and angling away from blows. Your character's Defense increases by 1 against unarmed strikes or weapons that use the Brawl Skill, and attackers suffer an additional –1 penalty to target her head.

Defensive Jab (••): Your character interrupts attacks with well-timed punches from the lead hand. Any time an opponent misses with a Brawl or Weaponry attack, your character inflicts one point of bashing damage which ignores armor. If your character Dodges, change this to one point of bashing damage per *two* successes that exceed the opponent's attack successes (a minimum of one, but round fractions down).

Knockout Artist (•••): Your character knows how to knock someone out. She now treats the target's Size as 1 lower at all times for the purposes of inflicting the Stunned Tilt, reflecting her ability to casually hit someone in the head. If you suffer a penalty to target the head as a true specified target, treat the target's Size as 2 lower for the purpose of inflicting the Tilt.

Combination (••••): Your character learns to fire off several blows in rapid succession, so that if one hits, the others often follow. If your character's Brawl strike succeeds, roll her Dexterity dots as dice and add successes to damage to reflect other blows striking home.

Out for the Count (•••••): When your character knocks someone out they don't get back up any time soon. When she inflicts the Stunned Tilt it not only lasts for a number of turns equal to the damage she inflicted, but it produces true unconsciousness for that period unless the victim spends a point of Willpower.

Chain Weapons (Style: • to ••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Dexterity •••, Athletics ••, Weaponry ••

Style Tags: Flexible

Effect: Your character knows how to use a length of chain as a weapon. These maneuvers require at least a yard's (or meter's) worth of chain and can be any design from a martial artist's chain whip to one ripped off the sprocket of a motorcycle. The Style is taught among traditional Chinese weapon styles but is also favored among everyday street gangs.

Imposing Defense (•): Your character spins her chain around, creating a whirling metal barrier between her and her opponent. Sacrificing her Defense, and she inflicts her weapon damage rating + 1 in bashing damage to any opponent who attempts an unarmed or melee attack against her that turn.

Bring Down the House (••): Handy in rooms with chandeliers or dodgy support beams, your character lashes her chain around some part of the environment over an opponent's head and then gives it a good yank. She makes an attack against an object with a penalty for the object's Size (use the specified target chart in the **Chronicles of Darkness Rulebook**, p. 92 as a guideline). If successful, she inflicts bashing damage equal to the object's Structure on all characters within range. Characters with their turn still available can Dodge, with successes removing damage.

Combat Archery (Style: • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Athletics ••, Quick Draw (Bow) •

Style Tags: Archery

Effect: Your character uses a bow for rapid draws that riddle opponents with arrows. She knows how to move across the battlefield while firing from any angle. This Style is about trick shots and using archery in the thick of a fight. It uses a dice pool of Dexterity + Athletics for its attacks.

Rapid Nock (•): Your character has trained herself to have another arrow set and her bow drawn within a heartbeat of her last shot. As long as there is a supply of arrows in reach she can make an attack every turn without taking an action to position them on the string. Also, ignore the bow's Initiative penalty.

Reflex Aiming (••): Your character knows how to time her shots to hit her opponents and not her allies. Ignore penalties for firing a bow into close combat.

Parthian Shot (•••): Your character feints retreat to lure an opponent in for a close-range shot. The first time in a turn an opponent attempts a close-range attack, you may choose to Dodge as normal. However, any successes in excess of your opponent's are applied as attack successes with your bow against him.

Rain of Arrows (••••): Your character fires a group of shots at multiple opponents in the blink of an eye. She can attack with a bow as an autofire medium burst with three arrows hitting up to three different targets.

Drawback: This maneuver sacrifices distance for speed. Triple all range penalties for medium and long distance.

Trick Shot (•••••): Your character rolls, leaps, and runs along walls while firing arrows in any direction. Your character can fire her bow simultaneously while taking an Athletics action, including maneuvers from Movement Styles. This imposes a –2 penalty to both rolls.

Falconry (Style: • to ••••)

Prerequisites: This Merit works in conjunction with any predatory bird of at least Size 2. The character must possess Wits •••, Animal Ken •••, and share the Bonded Condition with the bird.

Style Tags: Creature (Claw)

Effect: Your bird performs incredible feats at your command. You purchase this Merit for your character, who may apply it to any bird she shares the Bonded Condition with after a reasonable amount of time training together. Used for both hunting and sport, this practice has roots going back into antiquity and among numerous cultures. While not as widespread now as in the past, finding a trainer for this style is still relatively easy. Unless otherwise noted, these Merits constitute actions the bird takes independently, with only a

simple, one-word or gesture command. Thus, your character does not have to dedicate an action to make them happen. Additionally, possession of this Merit allows your character to spend Willpower to benefit the bird's actions in her presence.

Predator's Vigil (•): The presence of your bird instinctively wards off prey animals. Even a flock of pigeons or swarm of rats won't come too close when a natural predator circles the skies. Any creature of equal or smaller Size than your bird in his immediate vicinity has the Shaken Condition applied to them for any action other than hiding or fleeing the area.

Flyby (••): Your character commands her bird to dive past an enemy at high speed, creating a distraction. Roll Presence + Intimidation against an opponent's Resolve + Composure as an attack action for the bird. If successful, the opponent takes a –3 penalty to his next action.

Retrieve Item (•••): Your bird knows how to grab small items and bring them back to you, even snatching them from someone's hand. On your character's turn she can designate any object of the bird's Size or smaller within her and her bird's field of vision that the bird will retrieve. An opponent actively holding onto an item treats this as a Disarm maneuver, but if successful the bird's roll is automatically considered an exceptional success. This generally requires the bird make an all-out attack.

Rake the Eyes (••••): Your character commands her bird to claw at an opponent's eyes. Take a –1 penalty to attack. A successful attack applies the Blinded Tilt.

Grappling (Style, • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Stamina •••, Strength ••, Athletics ••, Brawl ••

Style Tag: Grappling

Effect: Grappling's first three dots are covered in the **Chronicles of Darkness Rulebook**. This section presents additional Grappling maneuvers. Some extend the style to the fourth and fifth dot. Others are alternatives to those listed in the core, or present multiple maneuvers. By acquiring maneuvers according to the rules on p. 44, characters may learn these instead of or in addition to maneuvers with the same dot ranking.

Standing Throw (•): Your character knows how to toss someone over his hip, trip, or sweep her while keeping his footing. He may inflict the Knocked Down Tilt as a grappling maneuver, but if he remains standing his opponent automatically breaks free.

Small Joint Manipulation (••): By accepting a –2 penalty to the attack roll, your character may immediately dislocate or otherwise bend the opponent's fingers in one hand (or toes in one foot, in some circumstances) the wrong way. This occurs instead of any other maneuver, inflicting one point of bashing damage per two successes (round down, but always at least one) and the Arm or Leg Wrack Tilt. If the attack targets a hand, it can no longer hold objects until the associated damage heals. Optionally, you may assign the Tactical (Street) Style Tag to this maneuver to represent a form of "underhanded" fighting.

Ippon (•••): *Additional Prerequisite: Takedown Maneuver.* While using Drop Prone with the Takedown Maneuver, your character hurls his opponent to the ground with exceptional force. Double the damage of the takedown for the purpose of inflicting the Stunned Tilt, but not as actual damage.

Dynamic Guard (••••): While prone, your character uses his body to shake and redirect his enemy. Reduce the opponent's dice pool to grapple by your character's Dexterity. Unfortunately, your character can't get up from prone while using this maneuver.

Lock Flow (••••): *Additional Prerequisite: Joint Lock Maneuver.* When your character's opponent slips out of one lock you know how to go with the motion and trap her in another. You gain +2 to grapple rolls when you declare ahead of time that you're attempting a joint lock.

Tap or Snap (•••••): *Additional Prerequisite: Joint Lock Maneuver.* If your character succeeds in a grapple in the turn after applying the Joint Lock maneuver, he may allow the opponent to choose between accepting the Beaten Down Condition, or suffering an Arm or Leg Wrack (attacker's choice) and lethal damage equal to the successes scored, as your character breaks or dislocates the relevant limb.

Positional Dominance (•••••): Your character knows how to hurt and tire an opponent from any position, crushing the life out of him. No matter which maneuver you choose on a successful grapple, your character inflicts one point of bashing damage per two successes scored, rounding down, but always inflicting at least one point. If your character chooses a damaging maneuver, add this to the damage inflicted. You may choose not to inflict this damage.

K-9 (Style, • to ••••)

Prerequisite: This Merit works in conjunction with a dog of least Size 3. The character must possess Wits •••, Animal Ken •••, and share the Bonded Condition with the dog.

Style Tags: Creature (Bite), Tactical (Police)

Effect: Under your supervision a dog may perform exceptional actions. You purchase this Merit for your character, who may apply it to any dog she shares the Bonded Condition with after a reasonable amount of training time together. Police and military forces are the place to go to learn to work with an animal in combat, but independent trainers might know this style as well.

Note that each maneuver includes the special ability to never require an Animal Ken roll to order its use. Your character's dog obeys without a second's pause.

Detection (•): Your character's dog has been trained to detect a certain class of substances by smell and indicate its location. Choose from one of the following: Drugs, Explosives, Tracks, People, and Corpses. When your character works with his dog it gains the Rote benefit (re-roll failed dice) on Wits + Survival rolls to detect the target substances. You may purchase this Merit multiple times for different categories.

Targeted Bite (••): Your character may command his dog to target specific body parts. Reduce penalties to attack specific targets by –2.

Tactical Positioning (•••): The character's dog knows how to position itself to make it difficult for opponents to

fight you both. When acting side by side against a single opponent, one of the pair gains +1 to Defense against that opponent, and the other benefits from +2 to attack rolls targeting the opponent. Your character decides which participant gets the offensive or defensive bonus at the beginning of each turn. Finally, you never take a penalty to ranged combat rolls to avoid shooting the dog, because he avoids your line of fire.

Takedown Bite (••••): At your character's command, his dog may inflict a Drop Prone or Hold grappling maneuver on a target if it hits with a successful bite attack. The target may be no more the double the dog's Size, however. This immediately initiates a grapple. Dogs may employ the above maneuvers along with Break Free, Control (opponent's) Weapon, and Damage.

Kino Mutai (Style • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity ••, Resolve •••, Brawl ••

Style Tags: Enraged, Street

Effect: Your character learns to bite opponents, tear at soft tissues and gouge eyes with special skills. This is sometimes called "Kino Mutai" in Filipino martial arts, but it can be learned by anyone uninhibited enough to use these unconventional methods to the greatest extent possible for humans. Thus, this Fighting Style only works for beings with a human body plan and a decent set of teeth.

Trained Bite (•): If your character prevails in a grapple she may bite harder than normal, targeting sensitive parts of an opponent's anatomy. This acts as the Damage maneuver, but inflicts an additional two points of bashing damage. Vampires, werewolves in humanoid form, and other monsters with particularly potent bite attacks cause one additional damage of the same type (potentially lethal) when using this maneuver.

Ripping (••): Your character overcomes squeamishness and distractions to grab and tear earlobes, eyelids, and other soft, loose parts. She doesn't pause before ripping out hair by the scalp. None of these injuries are life-threatening, but they inflict pain. If you win a grappling roll with more successes than the opponent's Resolve, she may use the Ripping maneuver, which inflicts an appropriate Tilt like Blinded or Deafened but only inflicts one point of bashing damage.

Trained Gouge (•••): While grappling, your character can drive her fingers into an enemy's eyes with exceptional force and persistence. If you win a grappling roll and score at least three successes, you may opt for the Gouge maneuver. This inflicts the Blinded Tilt, but unlike typical cases your character maintains this Tilt until the opponent Breaks Free, Restrains your character, or renders the arm unable to function.

Continuous Bite (••••): Your character knows how to apply pressure, rip flesh, and use the rest of her body's musculature to enhance a bite. In a grapple, she may inflict lethal damage with the Damage maneuver by tearing off strips of her opponent's flesh.

Martial Arts (Style • to •••••)

Prerequisites: Resolve •••, Dexterity •••, Athletics ••, Brawl ••

Style Tags: Striking

Effect: The Martial Arts Style in the **Chronicles of Darkness Rulebook** represents a generic unarmed striking style. The following maneuvers are alternatives to those listed. Using the options for purchasing maneuvers on **p. 44**, characters may acquire these maneuvers alongside or instead of the others with the same dot ranking.

Leg Kick (•): Your character knows how to kick an opponent's legs out from under him. She might use a Thai-style round kick or drive her heel into his kneecap. If she reduces her Defense by 1 while concentrating on low kicks, she'll cause the Leg Wrack Tilt if her Brawl attack inflicts at least one damage that turn. She doesn't suffer the usual penalty for targeting a leg. Note that trying to hit the *other* leg for a knockdown doesn't use this maneuver, but the normal rules. However, using Leg Kick on subsequent attacks lengthens the duration of the Leg Wrack by attaching the Tilt to additional damage.

Cutting Elbow (••): When striking with an elbow, your character targets thin skin in the opponent's scalp with the aim of ripping it open. She only suffers a –2 penalty to attack when she wishes to inflict the Blinded Condition on an opponent with human-like anatomy because when she hits and inflicts at least one point of bashing damage, blood from the scalp wound washes over the opponent's eyes. This maneuver may also be purchased through the Tactics (Street) Style Tag.

Trapping (•••): This maneuver has a lot of names, including "sticking hands" or "scissors." Using it, your character knows how to control her opponent's limbs so they can't be used to block incoming strikes. By making limb-to-limb physical contact, she can sense and counter her opponent's reactions. If she hits with a Brawl attack, she may set aside as many successes as her Brawl Skill and add these to her Brawl attack next turn. If she sets aside all successes, the first attack inflicts no damage, but makes contact for the follow up. She loses this advantage if the opponent leaves hand-to-hand range and she can't or won't follow.

Inch Force (••••): Your character knows how to swiftly strike across extremely short distances. She can hit hard with an inch of movement, or smash with a shoulder, hip, or head butt. When an opponent tries to grab your character she's entitled to one immediate counterattack per turn as an additional reflexive action (multiple grab attempts during the turn don't entitle her to additional counterattacks). Roll Strength + Brawl – Defense as usual. If the attack scores more successes than the opponent's Strength, she automatically breaks free of the grab and inflicts standard Brawl damage as well.

High Momentum Strike (•••••): Tornado kicks, spinning backfists, and flying knees are hard to pull off, but in the right circumstances can be devastating. If your character has a higher Initiative rank, she may wait for an opponent to attack with a Brawl or Weaponry strike. If the opponent scores 0 successes, your character may attempt an immediate counterattack, using her action for the turn on a leaping and/or spinning attack. If the counterattack hits it knocks the opponent down. In addition, roll the character's Brawl dots and add it to the attack's total damage.

Mounted Combat (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Athletics ••, Animal Ken ••

Style Tags: Archery, Heavy Melee, Light Melee, Tactical (Police)

Effect: Your character fights from horseback using the animal's size and maneuverability to make her attacks more effective. While trained cavalry regiments are largely a thing of the past, many police departments around the world still have officers who use techniques like these in the modern day.

Steady Saddle (•): Your character knows how to position herself in the saddle to attack an opponent without risking being dismounted or hurting her horse. Your character gains a +3 bonus to any rolls for staying mounted during combat.

Fixed Charge (••): Your character and her horse charge headlong at her opponent. She gains the benefits from both charging (though you move up to twice your horse's Speed rather than your character's) and an all-out attack. Both she and her horse lose Defense for the rest of the turn.

Skirmishing (•••): Your character's attacks are designed to harass her opponents, moving in range to strike and then out again before the counterattack. Her horse can travel half its Speed before her attack and the rest after as one move. She suffers a –2 penalty to her attack for the turn but both her and her mount gain +2 to Defense.

Rearing Beast (••••): Your character has trained her horse to be an intimidating and dangerous opponent in the thick of combat. Instead of attacking, roll Wits + Animal Ken and add successes to attack rolls made by her horse.

Powered Projectile (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Athletics ••, Firearms ••

Style Tags: Pistol

Effect: Your character is comfortable using premodern ranged weapons like crossbows, slingshots, and blowguns. Though long ago replaced by firearms, these weapons remain popular for hunting and are widely available in some countries.

Quick Reload (•): Your character has trained herself on the steps to reload her weapon to the point it's ingrained in her muscle memory. She reloads one turn faster than normal (to a minimum of a reflexive action).

Intercept Shot (••): Your character can shoot a projectile out of the air with her own. This maneuver is not capable of stopping bullets, though it could be used to deflect a grenade if you're feeling lucky. Any turn your character spends aiming she can make an attack against a thrown object with a –2 penalty (in addition to the normal penalties for attacking a small object). A successful hit deflects it a number of meters (or yards) equal to damage in a random direction.

Penetration (•••): Your character knows how to best exploit the weaknesses in a target's armor. She can add +2 to her weapon's armor piercing rating for her next attack.

Drawback: This shot requires intense concentration. Your character loses her Defense any turn she uses this maneuver.

Skewer (••••): Your character uses her projectiles to impale parts of an opponent's anatomy. When attacking a specified target, reduce the penalty by –2, and any inflicted Tilts require the victim to roll Stamina + Strength – damage inflicted to remove a projectile before it's resolved.

Spear and Bayonet (Style; • to •••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Dexterity ••, Weaponry ••

Style Tags: Pole Weapons

Effect: Your character is trained with long weapons that end in a point. This could be anything from a traditional spear to a fixed bayonet on a modern rifle. This Style has countless variations around the world but is historically incorporated as part of military training.

Firm Footing (•): Your character braces herself with her weapon to skewer a charging opponent. Any opponent attempting an all-out or charge attack against your character takes her weapon's damage automatically before he makes his attack roll. Armor subtracts from this, but then will not apply to any attacks your character makes in the same turn.

Keep at Bay (••): Your character can threaten an opponent with her weapon to prevent maneuvering. Choose an opponent with a shorter weapon; if that opponent takes any action other than backing away or Dodging he loses his Defense against your character's next attack.

Drawback: Spend a point of Willpower to activate this maneuver.

Strike and Develop (•••): Your character stabs an opponent with her weapon then turns the blade before removing it, leaving a more grisly wound. Attacks made with her weapon that inflict lethal damage causes the victim to bleed out, causing one point of lethal damage for a number of turns equal to her successes on the attack roll. Subsequent attacks can add to the total number of turns but never cause more than one point of lethal damage per turn in bleeding to the victim. She loses her Defense any turn she uses this maneuver.

Staff Fighting (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Strength ••, Dexterity •••, Weaponry ••

Style Tags: Pole Weapons

Effect: Your character uses a staff as her weapon of choice. These maneuvers are usually performed with a quarterstaff or bo staff, but anything of a suitable length and shape like a walking stick or a heavy curtain rod will work as well.

Short Grip (•): Your character moves her grip to the end of the staff, maximizing reach but losing speed. She gains a +1 to attack at the cost of her staff's +1 bonus to Defense. You can change your character's grip once per turn reflexively before taking an action.

Thwack Weapon (••): Your character slaps away an opponent's weapon with the tip of her staff. She can Disarm with a roll of Strength + Weaponry contested by an opponent's Strength + Athletics. If successful, the opponent drops his weapon at his feet. On an exceptional success, your character knocks the weapon a number of meters (or yards) away equal to her successes rolled.

Vaulting Defense (•••): Your character knows how to use her staff to rapidly reposition herself in a fight. Spend a point of Willpower; your character can add her dots in Melee to her Defense against one attack per turn.

Tornado Strike (••••): Your character spins her staff rapidly in a circle, hitting opponents all around her. She treats her staff attack as an autofire medium burst against up to three targets of her choice within range.

Strength Performance (Style: • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Stamina ••, Athletics ••

Style Tag: Movement (Strong)

Effect: While the Strength Attribute covers all forms of issuing bodily force, your character has specifically trained in lifting, pushing, and pulling enormous weights. He learned this as an Olympic-style weightlifter, strongman competitor, or performer. This doesn't help your character hit things, but if he does, anything at the other end is going to break and hurt.

In addition to learning maneuvers, at ••• dots your character can actually increase in Size after adding prodigious amounts of muscle. You may purchase the Giant Merit for your character during play, or if he began play as Small-Framed, get back the Experience value of those Merit dots while increasing to Size 5, and losing its benefits. (Your character can't do one after the other — there's a limit to what her skeleton can support.) Your character must have had Strength Performance ••• for at least one year, and you must tell the Storyteller your character is trying to get bigger. No character can move from Giant to Size 7 this way, and any Size change is optional — small people can still max out in this style.

Strength Tricks (•): Your character combines trained strength with a practical knowledge of physics to perform impressive, if minor, feats of strength. He can rip phone books in half, bend rebar, and smash bricks with his bare hands. The character benefits from a +2 bonus to Performance and Intimidation rolls where he can demonstrate his talents, and an additional +1 to other non-combat feats of Strength.

Lifting (••): Your character can perform incredible feats of raw strength. When attempting a feat of strength that requires a Strength + Stamina roll, you gain the Rote benefit — re-roll failed dice. This does not aid running, jumping, or combat rolls, but does aid in attempts to damage relatively immobile, inanimate objects. In that case your character gains the Rote benefit on a combat dice pool no larger than his Strength + Stamina.

Push/Pull (•••): Have you ever seen someone pull a tractor trailer or airplane with their teeth? Your character's all over that. If your character's goal is to move an object laterally, double her effective Strength. If the object is on wheels or friction has otherwise been minimized, multiply her Strength by 5. Practical considerations may require equipment such as ropes and a harness, and the quality of this equipment may provide a bonus to the roll.

Stronger Than You (••••): If your character succeeds at Strength-based tasks, he does so with an increased level of performance. You don't gain bonus dice for Strength-related rolls but if you roll at least one success, add +1 success to the total. This *does* apply to combat, making this character capable of bone-cracking blows and grips.

Systema (Style: • to •••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Athletics •••, Wits ••

Style Tags: Movement (Agility), Tactical (Military)

Effect: Your character learns to move with exceptional suppleness, rolling with blows and obstacles. She redirects incoming force not as a technique, but an instinct. These abilities are often taught within Systema, a Russian martial art developed for intelligence services and special operations. It can also reflect the advanced body skills taught by "soft" martial arts such as Tai Chi or Aikido.

Rolling (•): When knocked prone, your character relaxes, tucks, and rolls with the momentum. She easily spins to face any direction she wishes. She doesn't suffer that usual –2 penalty to attacks while Knocked Down or otherwise prone. If she suffers any damage for falling or impacting against an unyielding surface like the hood of a car, roll her Dexterity; each success removes one point of bashing damage (this is not effective against sources of lethal damage — you can't roll with impalement). She benefits from this in addition to any other action she might take to mitigate damage.

Balance (••): Your character instinctively aligns her posture and bends with incoming force to keep her balance. Attempts to inflict the Knocked Down Tilt or Drop Prone grappling maneuver must achieve two additional successes.

Combat Posture (•••): Your character's posture and sensitivity are strong enough to knock down anyone who tests his balance against yours. Your character's Brawl and Weaponry attacks inflict the Knocked Down Tilt whenever they score successes that equal or exceed the victim's Strength. If an attack would have already delivered this result (such as with a weapon that inflicts the Knockdown effect) it does so with particular force, inflicting an additional point of damage.

Thrown Weapons (Style: • to ••)

Prerequisites: Dexterity •••, Athletics ••, Quick Draw with a thrown weapon Specialty •

Style Tags: Light Melee, Agile

Effect: Knives, darts, throwing stars, and tomahawks are all weapons your character can send flying in her enemy's direction. Many warrior cultures have used thrown projectiles in wartime or for hunting purposes and may teach this Style. Also, similar techniques are found among circus and sideshow acts. These maneuvers may only be performed with edged weapons Size 1 or smaller.

Practiced Toss (•): Your character knows how to throw her weapon with a quick and fluid motion. Add her Athletics score to Initiative when using a thrown weapon.

Impalement Arts (••): A well-placed throw staples an opponent's limbs to the environment. If your character succeeds in damaging a specified target arm, leg, or hand with a thrown weapon, she inflicts the Impaled Tilt.

Drawback: The heft needed to make her throw penetrate leaves your character vulnerable. She loses her Defense any turn she uses this maneuver.

Two Weapon Fighting (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Wits •••, Fighting Finesse ••, Weaponry •••

Style Tags: Flexible, Light Melee

Effect: Your character fights with a weapon in each hand. She can amplify her attacks by using them together or balance between attack and defense by using one weapon for each. Different martial arts focus on different sets of weapons. Some employ a rapier and dagger, or a *katana* and *wakizashi*, while others use sticks or two light swords. This Style can be used to replicate any of them. Unless your character possesses the Ambidextrous Merit she takes the usual –2 penalty for using a weapon in her off-hand. Neither weapon can be above Size 2 for performing these maneuvers.

Balanced Grip (•): Your character knows how to use her weapons so they're not awkward to hold. Your character does not count her weapons' Initiative penalties as long as her off-hand weapon's rating is the same or the lower of the two.

Protective Striking (••): Your character uses her off-hand weapon to deflect attacks. She adds her off-hand weapon's bonus to her Defense for the first attack made against her in a turn. If her off-hand weapon has no bonus then add +1 instead.

Dual Swipe (•••): Your character attacks with both of her weapons simultaneously against one target. As part of an all-out melee attack, add her off-hand weapon's bonus to her attack roll and reduce her target's Defense by 1. If her off-hand weapon has no bonus then add +1 instead.

Double Strike (••••): Your character attacks two different targets simultaneously. Spend a point of Willpower and designate two targets in close range of your character. Take the highest Defense and –1 to the dice pool. Choose which weapon's damage applies to which target. This maneuver cannot be used with Dual Swipe.

For example, if you're up against two opponents with 4 and 6 Defense, and you have a 2L and 1L weapon, you would take –7 to Double Strike (the 6 Defense, with an additional –1). If you rolled three successes, one opponent would take five points of lethal damage, and the other four points of lethal damage — your choice which.

Weapon and Shield (Style; • to ••••)

Prerequisites: Strength •••, Stamina •••, Weaponry ••

Style Tags: Light Melee

Effect: Your character knows how to fight from behind a shield with a one-handed weapon. These maneuvers strike a balance between protection and offense and are used in tandem with others, such as in a Viking shield wall or riot police formation.

Shield Bash (•): Your character slams her shield into an oncoming opponent, disrupting his attack. When Dodging add her shield's Size to her pool. If she reduces an opponent's attack successes to 0 then any additional successes inflict bashing damage.

Boar's Snout (••): Your character throws everything into a forward charge, trusting in her shield to protect her. Using a weapon and shield, your character can all-out attack and retain her shield's Size bonus to Defense for the turn. If this maneuver is used the same turn by other allies with shields, then add an additional +1 to Defense for each.

Pin Weapon (•••): Your character uses her shield to trap an opponent's weapon. If an opponent misses a melee attack against your character he is automatically disarmed.

Tortoise Shell (••••): Your character knows how to position herself so that she's completely protected by her shield. When using a shield she is considered behind cover with Durability equal to the shield's size plus one for each shield-wielding ally in her immediate vicinity.

Individual Merits

The following Merits are individual benefits that can be attached to multiple styles, or purchased on their own using the Style Tag rules, where applicable.

Armed Restraint (••)

Prerequisites: Staff Fighting •••

Effect: Your character knows how to use a pole with a hook or noose on the end of it to restrain animal and human targets. Using a suitable weapon, such as a catch pole or shepherd's crook, your character can grapple and immediately apply the Hold maneuver on success. During subsequent turns her opponent's grapple rolls are penalized by the weapon's damage rating.

Boot Party (••)

Prerequisites: Brawl ••

Style Tags: Striking

Effect: Your character understands the effectiveness of grinding her heel into a delicate part of a downed opponent's anatomy. When attacking an opponent in the prone position, she may make an unarmed attack at a –3 penalty in addition to normal modifiers. Any damage inflicted is lethal.

Clinch Strike (•)

Prerequisites: Brawl ••

Style Tags: Striking, Grappling, Tactical (Street)

Effect: Most people will instinctively grab anyone they want to hit, but your character has trained to hit hard and accurately from a clinch position, using short punches, elbows, and knees. She inflicts standard Brawl damage when initiating a grapple instead of sacrificing the opportunity to damage someone in order to grab.

Covert Operative (•)

Prerequisites: Wits •••, Dexterity •••, Stealth ••

Style Tags: Tactical (Military)

Effect: Your character is trained in getting the jump on her opponents. She creeps up on unsuspecting enemies from the shadows and neutralizes them before anyone realizes anything's happening. When your character ambushes an opponent, the victim loses the 10-again quality on his

roll to notice the attack. Even if he successfully notices your character, your character acts at +3 Initiative in the first turn.

Ground and Pound (•••)

Prerequisites: Brawl ••

Style Tags: Striking, Grappling, Tactical (Street)

Effect: Your character skillfully uses gravity to drop a fist, elbow, knee, or other strike on a prone opponent. When using Brawl to strike or inflict the Damage grappling maneuver on a prone opponent, you may declare your character uses this maneuver. You gain the rote benefit (re-roll failed dice) to your attack, but automatically fall prone; and if grappled, your opponent automatically breaks free.

Ground Fighter (•••)

Prerequisites: Wits •••, Dexterity •••, Brawl ••

Style Tags: Grappling

Effect: Your character knows how to fight from her back. Many mixed martial arts styles emphasize being able to fight from the ground. Brawl and weaponry attacks do not gain the +2 bonus to attack your character when prone. She can perform the Stand Up maneuver.

- **Stand Up):** When grappling an opponent from the prone position you can stand up without having to Break Free of the grapple.

Headbutt (•)

Prerequisites: Brawl ••

Style Tags: Striking, Grappling

Effect: Your character has found few arguments she can't end by ramming her skull into a softer part of the human anatomy. This Merit allows for a new grappling maneuver:

- **Headbutt:** Your character inflicts the Stunned Tilt on her opponent. Each use of this maneuver in a scene imposes a –2 penalty as the shock and surprise of this tactic wears off.

Iron Chin (•• or ••••)

Prerequisites: Resolve •••, Stamina •••

Style Tags: Attitude (Determined), Striking, Tactical (Street)

Effect: Your character's taken her share of beatings and can't be scared by pain or the sight of her own blood. This Merit comes in two levels. At •• dots, she no longer suffers the Beaten Down Tilt from any amount of bashing damage. At •••• dots, she never suffers Beaten Down, *period*. This is probably more foolhardy than brave. If your chronicle doesn't feature conflicts where Beaten Down features prominently, don't use this Merit.

Phalanx Fighter (••)

Prerequisites: Weapon and Shield ••, Spear and Bayonet •

Effect: Your character is trained to wield a spear alongside a shield. She does not increase her spear's Strength requirement for using it one-handed as long as she's also using a shield. She can use a spear for any Weapon and Shield maneuvers.

Transfer Maneuver (Same Cost as Original Maneuver; see below)

Prerequisites: Intelligence ••, Wits •••. Your character must also possess at least ••• dots in both the original and new Skill that the maneuver applies to.

Style Tag: Special; see below.

Effect: Many styles teach unarmed methods as a prerequisite for armed methods, and vice versa. This maneuver allows your character to transfer a maneuver from a Brawl-based Fighting Style to a Weaponry-based Style, or vice versa. The maneuver must not depend on the physical presence of a weapon, in that it can be applied with empty hands. The Storyteller decides which maneuvers are appropriate, though this can only be used on maneuvers worth no more than ••• dots — after that, they're too specific to the original fighting method. Your character must know the maneuver in its original form, and you must purchase it again, at the same cost in dots and Experience.

Trunk Squeeze (••)

Prerequisites: Brawl ••

Style Tags: Creature (Constrictor), Grappling

Effect: By wrapping arms or legs around an opponent's torso, your character can practically crush the life out of him. While grappling, your character can use the Trunk Squeeze maneuver.

- **Trunk Squeeze:** Using a bear hug or leg scissors, your character crushes the opponent's torso, making it increasingly difficult to breathe. This maneuver inflicts one point of bashing damage and imposes a cumulative –1 to the opponent's grappling rolls for each round she maintains it. The penalty persists until after your character attempts another maneuver, or until the target Breaks Free. This maneuver doesn't work on anyone who doesn't need to breathe, or victims with a Size at least 2 higher than the attacker's.

Retain Weapon (••)

Prerequisites: Wits ••, Brawl ••

Style Tags: Light Weapon, Pistol, Tactical (Police, Military)

Effect: Your character has trained to resist being disarmed. Police and military forces often teach this, but your character might learn this as part of a traditional martial art, as part of a shooting course, or as a member of a private security service. When an attacker attempts to use the Control Weapon or Disarm grappling maneuvers to take his weapon, or otherwise take it away in combat, reduce successes by your character's Brawl dots.